

## English 6110 • Seminar in Marianne Moore and Elizabeth Bishop • Fall 2006

"Use your imagination, and pay attention to language." Adrienne Rich

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**Office hours:** MF 3:30-4:30  
Tu 12:30-2:30  
and by appointment  
**Class meets:** Tu 4:30-7:00  
Morrill 310

submitted to the editor (me) and sent to two readers (your classmates) for review. Submissions are blind; hence, the author's name should appear on the cover letter only. Authors may use the readers' and editor's comments to revise their papers for resubmission (and a grade). The original version of the paper will not receive a grade, but failure to participate fully in the submission and review process could result in a deduction from the paper's final grade.

**Texts:** Marianne Moore, *The Complete Poems*  
Marianne Moore, *Becoming Marianne Moore*  
Marianne Moore, *The Complete Prose*  
Marianne Moore, *The Selected Letters*  
Elizabeth Bishop, *The Complete Poems: 1927-1979*  
Elizabeth Bishop, *The Collected Prose*  
Elizabeth Bishop, *One Art*  
and selected works on handouts or reserve

**Course Description and Objectives:** Moore and Bishop met when Moore was an established poet and Bishop a college student. They liked each other immediately and became lifelong friends. Both have a precise eye for detail, both write about animals, and although both resist easy classification, both are highly regarded by a wide range of poets. The seminar will examine not only their poetry and prose but also their respective generations and the dynamics of influence between mentor and protégé. Students will develop their expertise as scholars of literature by analyzing primary and secondary sources. They should likewise develop expertise in both oral and written expression.

**Instructional Method:** Seminar

### Requirements and Grades:

**team-teach 2 classes** (10% each): With a partner, lead the seminar for a day. During the first 75 minutes of class, your team should provide a critical context for the topic and engage the class in discussion. Creativity is encouraged. Some research is necessary, but this is *not* an oral report. Plan your goals and strategies with your partner, so that you really *teach*. You will be evaluated on your level of preparation and your effectiveness in teaching the class.

**article-length paper** (50%): Write an article-length paper (about 5000 words, 18-20 typed pages). Present an original argument within a context of secondary sources (see attached Papers for Graduate Seminars). Use MLA style. In order to simulate the process of journal submission and review, students will function as both contributors and consulting editors for a hypothetical journal, *The Moore/Bishop Review*. The original paper (well beyond first draft quality) plus two photocopies and a cover letter will be

**final examination** (30%): Two-hour essay exam.

**course grade:** 0-59 = F; 60-69 = D; 70-79 = C; 80-89 = B; 90-100 = A

**Attendance:** Attendance and promptness are required. Repeated, unexplained absences will result in failure of the course.

**Late and Make-up Work:** I will accept late work or give make-up exams only if students have made prior arrangements with me. Such arrangements must be made as soon as possible before the due date or, in cases of emergency, as soon as possible thereafter.

**Drop/Add Policy:** The Course Schedule below includes drop and add dates.

**Academic Integrity:** All members of the Oklahoma State University community are entrusted with academic integrity, which encompasses the fundamental values of honesty, trust, respect, fairness, and responsibility. For information about policies and procedures, see <<http://academicintegrity.okstate.edu/>>.

**Special Accommodations:** If you feel that you have a disability and need special accommodations, I will work with you and the Office of Student Disability Services (315 Student Union) to provide reasonable accommodations so that you have a fair opportunity to perform in this class. Please advise me of any disabilities and the desired accommodations immediately following the first class meeting.

## Course Schedule:

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|----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Tu 8/22  | Introduction to course<br><br>13 Moore poems from <i>Others: An Anthology of the New Verse</i> (1917), ed. Alfred Kreymborg; handout                                                                                                                                                                          |
| M 8/28   | Last day to add a course (nonrestrictive)<br>Last day to drop a course with no grade and no fees<br>Last day to withdraw from all classes with 100% refund                                                                                                                                                    |
| Tu 8/29  | <i>Observations: BMM</i> 39-162<br><br>Also: <i>SL</i> (1-72); <i>BMM</i> (440-49, 465-84); and <i>CPr</i> (31-40)                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| F 9/1    | Last day to add a course (restrictive: with approval of the instructor)<br>Last day to drop a course with 50% fees                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Tu 9/5   | Moore as a gendered poet<br><br>Team teachers: _____<br><br><i>Observations</i> , continued: “Roses Only,” “Those Various Scalpels,” “Sojourn in the Whale,” “Marriage”<br><br>Also: <i>BMM</i> (423-37); <i>SL</i> (73-210); and <i>CPr</i> (47-62, 64-75, 79-82, 84-100, 112-14, 120-31, 143-46)            |
| Tu 9/12  | Moore as a letter writer: selections from <i>SL</i> above, plus later letters to Bryher, Williams, Eliot, Pound, and Stevens (see index to <i>SL</i> )<br><br>Team teachers: _____<br><br>From <i>Observations</i> : “New York,” “An Octopus”                                                                 |
| Tu 9/19  | Moore as a literary critic: selections from <i>CPr</i> above, plus <i>Dial</i> “Comments” ( <i>CPr</i> 149-223) and select reviews from the 1930s ( <i>CPr</i> 266-77, 290-96, 297-99, 301-03, 312-36, 339-49, 352-55, 357-64)<br><br>Team teachers: _____                                                    |
| Tu 9/26  | Moore in the 1930s: <i>CPo</i> 1-122; and select 1930s reviews, continued                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| Tu 10/3  | Moore and Bishop: their letters to one another in <i>SL</i> and <i>OA</i> ; Moore’s reviews of Bishop ( <i>CPr</i> 327-29, 406-08, 524-26); Bishop’s memoir of Moore ( <i>CPr</i> 121-56); Bishop’s “Roosters” and “Invitation to Miss Marianne Moore” ( <i>CPo</i> 35-39, 82-83)<br><br>Team teachers: _____ |
| Tu 10/10 | Fall Break                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Tu 10/17 | Bishop’s juvenilia and <i>North &amp; South: CPo</i> 211-28, 3-52<br><br><i>OA</i> (1-129)                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Tu 10/24 | Bishop as a gendered poet<br><br>Team teachers: _____<br><br><i>North &amp; South</i> , continued; and <i>OA</i> 133-227                                                                                                                                                                                      |

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| Tu 10/31 | Bishop as a letter writer: selections from <i>OA</i> above plus later letters to Robert Lowell and Marianne Moore<br><br>Team teachers: _____                                                                                       |
| Tu 11/7  | <i>A Cold Spring</i> and <i>Questions of Travel: CPo</i> 55-135                                                                                                                                                                     |
| F 11/10  | Last day to drop a course (grade of “W”) except by petition<br>Last day to withdraw from all courses with automatic grades of “W”                                                                                                   |
| Tu 11/14 | <i>Geography III: “In the Waiting Room”</i> and “The Moose” ( <i>CPo</i> 159-61, 169-73)<br><br><b>Paper</b> (original plus 2 copies and cover letter) <b>due at noon in M205</b><br><br>Papers distributed to readers during class |
| Th 11/16 | <b>Readers’ evaluations due via e-mail by 10:00 p.m.</b>                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Tu 11/21 | Bishop as a prose writer: <i>Collected Prose</i><br><br>Team teachers: _____                                                                                                                                                        |
| Tu 11/28 | Moore’s late poems: <i>CPo</i> 125-247                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| F 12/1   | Last day to withdraw from all courses with assigned grades of “W” or “F”                                                                                                                                                            |
| Tu 12/5  | <i>Geography III</i> , continued, plus Bishop’s other late poems: <i>CPo</i> 159-192                                                                                                                                                |
| F 12/8   | <b>Revised paper due by 4:00 in my box in M205</b>                                                                                                                                                                                  |
| Tu 12/12 | <b>Final Examination, 6:00-7:50 p.m.</b>                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## Papers for Graduate Seminars

My standards approximate as nearly as possible those currently held by American scholars in the field of literature. These standards are highly conventionalized and thus, like other conventions, must be learned. Only by “speaking the language” of the profession can one gain an audience and hence make one’s own contribution to the professional community. The expectations for a scholarly/critical article, the prototype for most seminar papers, are summarized in *The MLA Style Manual*:

Current usage blurs the sharp distinction that was once observed between “scholarly,” or factually based, articles and “critical,” or theoretically based, articles. Either type requires the scholar to **demonstrate familiarity with the previous scholarship on the topic, suggest an original thesis, present supporting evidence, and point to the significance of the proposition advanced.** The best scholarly articles incorporate all four aspects in a proportion appropriate to the subject and audience. Failure to cover each adequately is probably the most frequent reason that journals reject articles for publication. [emphasis added]

To demonstrate familiarity with the previous scholarship on a topic, the scholar must, of course, be certain to acquire that familiarity. . . . After locating the pertinent materials, the scholar assimilates them and relates them to the new thesis. The clearer the connections between the two, the more cogent the article. Long paragraphs—or even pages—that do little more than list the previous scholarship usually reveal that the author has not adequately assimilated it.

The thesis proposed in a scholarly article should be significant—not a refutation of another scholar’s minor thesis or a trivial application of a tired theory to a work of literature. The statement of the thesis should have a prominent place in the article, and the wording should be as lucid and concise as possible. Theses that resist clear and concise statements often have flaws and need rethinking.

After stating the thesis, the scholar should present the supporting evidence. It is often wise to begin by reviewing the categories of evidence for each aspect of the thesis, thus giving readers a sense of what will follow, and then to take up each category of evidence seriatim, making certain that the evidence is both valid and relevant to the thesis. Once all the evidence has been presented, it usually helps—except in very brief articles—to summarize the ways that the evidence supports the thesis.

Scholars often neglect the final part of the scholarly article—the significance of the thesis; yet it is this feature that ultimately commends the article to readers. The author should devote as much effort to considering and expressing the significance of the thesis as to supporting it, even though this concluding section may occupy only the final paragraph or two of the article.

Assuming minimal expectations are met, grades reflect primarily the significance of the thesis. Thus, according to the procedures above, the writer must convince me, the

skeptical reader, that the thesis is original and significant. Fluid, well-edited prose is expected. Students should consult the second edition of *The MLA Style Manual* on matters of style and documentation.

For additional clarification, students should consult *Biography* and other reputable journals to find examples of scholarly articles. Also, students are encouraged to seek my advice at any or all stages of the writing process, including finding a topic, compiling the bibliography, clarifying the thesis, organizing the supporting evidence, and revising the rough draft. Given enough time and sufficient motivation on the part of the student, I will help each student to understand the expectations for the assignment. (This applies to assignments other than papers, too.) A student desiring individualized help should therefore seek it as early as possible.